

Week 4: Video Transcript

Hello and welcome back. Welcome to your fourth week at the Jai Institute for Parenting. Once again, I thank you for making this commitment to yourself, your family, and the world. This is a movement that begins with one parent at a time, creating a revolution for children to be raised in a safe, beautiful world that cares deeply for the equality and the justice of childhood. And I'm so glad that you're here. We've spent the last three weeks exploring this space and this process. We have set intentions for yourself as an empowered parent, grounding into your strengths, your resources, and your personal values, and your challenges. We have differentiated for you the power over, power under, and power with parenting paradigms. The power with parenting paradigm is the empowered parenting paradigm. We laid out for you, the 10 pillars of empowered parenting, and I welcome you to be wherever you are at in this process. It can be a lot. It can feel as if there is an unattainable standard that you must reach in order to qualify as an empowered parent. And I assure you that we are not on a path together of perfection or proving yourself in any way. This is a deeply personal and internal journey. And wherever you are at is just fine. That might seem hard to swallow and hard to hear, but self-acceptance truly is the fertile soil where transformation happens and we're going to keep going. You're at the very beginning.

My intention today is to share with you the foundation at which all empowered parenting pillars are rested upon. When you learn those empowered parenting pillars may have seemed quite easy to say and quite easy to read, but to put it into action and to have it "work" is an entirely different animal. So we want to get very clear together at how these pillars thrive and how these pillars thrive, is working with a solid foundation of security. Today we're going to be discussing attachment science, breaking it down as simply as we possibly can for you to digest and take out into your day to day life. My intention also for you before any other information is hope. My intention for you is hope. Learning about attachment science is brand new and prioritizing attachment science is brand new in the field of parenting, parenting experts, educators and coaches. And it is unequivocally the most important understanding that we have as parents. Absolutely. And I can't wait to share this information with you. If this is not brand new for you, another go around with this information never hurts, and if this is brand new for you, welcome.

This is a lovely universe to be in, and it's going to be incredibly illuminating for you. If at any time it feels stressful or you feel a sense of doom, remember that you are okay, you are not broken. You are just exactly where you are meant to be in this process.

Daniel Siegel, the infamous Daniel Siegel, and Tina Payne Bryson have brought to us incredible work of attachment science, interpersonal neurobiology, and all kinds of other really fancy things that I can't wait to teach you about. And it has been shown that a secure attachment within a parent to themselves and to your past, as in you are at a state and a place of security with your past experiences and how they are showing up for you today. The state of security within yourself, the state of connection, coherence, acceptance, and safety within your head, your heart and your hands indicates the quality of security you create with your child or children. I will tell you that if your child does not feel safe, unconditionally loved, accepted, like they belong, a sense of deep connection that they feel, not just know, feel in their head, heart and hands. Then the 10 pillars of empowered parenting won't "work". And there is no judgment here. This is a big pill to swallow for many of us who simply want to do the right thing with our children, and we want to do the right tool and the right strategy. We want to say the right thing, follow the script, and we want it to work. We want to read the parenting book, and then we want to do the things in the parenting book, and we want them to work. We want peace, we want ease, and we want it yesterday. And what we must develop is a secure attachment beginning with ourselves. Take a nice deep breath into this statement. The quality of security you have within you to yourself, your stories, your experiences indicate the quality of security you can hold for you and your child.

Let's take this one step deeper. The quality of security you have in connection to yourself indicates the quality of connection and security you can create for you and your child. And that creates the quality of connection and security your child will have with themselves. So let's look at this in a broader context. And before I do that, let me define what attachment is. You're hearing things like connection, security, safety, belonging, and unconditional acceptance, and there is a definition here that I'll read. This was created by Mary Ainsworth and John Bowlby in the 1950s. So attachment science is not new in the theory and practice of being a human -- well, it's pretty new, less than a hundred years. And especially in the last decade or two, this has been the primary focus with parent educators and experts. So here we go. Attachment is the quality of psychological and emotional connection shared between a caregiver and a child that transcends all space and time. And if the last part of this definition is a little bit strange for you to hear, transcending all space and time, let's break that down into layman terms. So it is the quality of bonding between a caregiver and child that, that child will carry with them into their life for the rest of their time on this earth, in any context of relation, all space and all time. And this carries down the lineage.

Your attachment to yourself was created based on your caregiver's attachment to themselves, and on and on and on and on and on for generations upon generations. We do not exist on an island as parents. We are from a family. We are from a lineage. We receive inheritances from our parents like it or not. And this is no different with attachment. We have remembered that humans are born biologically wired to connect. That is our life blood. That is why we are here. We are here to connect deeply.

If our child does not feel connected to their parent because their parent is not connected to themselves, that is life or death for a child. And almost all behaviors in our children occur when that child is in a state of fight or flight, which we'll talk about in detail next week. They perceive that their life is in danger because the quality of connection and security that they are biologically hardwired for, is not being fulfilled. And it's not because mom or dad are bad, or wrong, or broken, or don't love their child. It's simply because we are just now learning the importance of emotional connection, psychological connection, and physical connection. For so long, we have been raising our children like dogs. And I say that with so much love in my heart for dogs. We have been raising our children like animals. And that's appropriate for dogs, demanding obedience and being the alpha and dominator, that helps a puppy feel safe. But for a child, that is the most dangerous way of relating. And if you're skeptical about what I'm saying here, this is a very interesting theory of the power over parenting paradigm, as it's rooted in domination, authority, obedience, needing to be the alpha, and any other kind of power, and that child is a threat to the alpha. And we're learning that that is the opposite strategy of success for our children that actually creates in our children, very high levels of stress, cortisol, and adrenaline in their bodies, and they are terrified. And children will do anything at all costs to secure their survival. Attachment is our survival system. We will do anything that we can, including not cry, even though we're sad, not cry, even though we're hungry, not cry, even though our diaper is wet, not cry, even though we're scared and we want to be held.

So let's look at this in a broader context, as I was saying. Even today, pediatricians, behavioral modification therapists, they are teaching parents to dismiss their children's cues. To pick up your baby when they're crying is to create a dependent, spoiled child. To "give in" to your child's disorientation and dysregulation is to teach them that bad behavior is okay. I have so many words about that, but we're going to take this a little bit at a time. So next week I'll go into a lot about the nervous system and dysregulation, and all behavior comes from a state of disorientation on the inside and not understanding how to communicate what we need and how we're feeling. But today we'll focus on attachment. So we have been encouraged for decades, generations to not meet our children's emotional, physical, psychological -- you could even say spiritual, if that speaks to you -- needs.



We were taught that simply feeding them, making sure that they have clothes and a home, and they're relatively safe is enough. And humans, we just don't work like that. We're complex. We have deep emotional needs. We have deep psychological needs. We have affection, physical needs that we need to thrive. We need these to thrive. And how we have been raised most likely is a lack of these needs being met. So what this creates is called an insecure attachment.

So let's work it out together how the attachment system is oriented. Remember I spoke to you last time about the head, the heart, and the hands of empowered parenting. Same thing goes here for attachment science. So when our primary caregiver meets our needs, is attuned to us, especially as infants, toddlers, and young children, meaning they hear our cries and they're curious, and they're willing to pick us up and try to understand. They hear our whining and our tantrums as a need for connection and safety and soothing. When our caregiver is curious about what our experience is and takes guesses to understand our thoughts and our inner world, that helps us make sense of who we are in time and space, our identity, our reality.

So a caregiver is attuning to our head by trying to understand what we're thinking. They're willing to look at life through our eyes. They're willing to look at life through where we are developmentally in our emotions and our nervous system and our brain. A secure attachment is a caregiver who responds to the heart, who is not intimidated or fearful of a child's cry. They're willing to be curious and explore, and they believe as a caregiver, they are competent and capable of supporting you through your emotions. And a secure attachment caregiver responds to a child in their body. They're there for them with affection, they're there to help them be regulated and they're there to show them that they matter. So let's break this down together. The quality of security in your early years with your primary attachment figure, the one who secured your survival and that you were cared for most consistently and regularly, we learn as an infant, first 10 months of life, that connection is either safe and dependable, life-giving, and good, or it is dangerous and not to be trusted.

The second part here is that the quality of security, the quality of consistent, attuned, warm, nurturing responses creates a belief in us that stress and intense emotion is temporary and survivable. That our body has the ability to sooth and reach a state of calm. Being in the wave of emotion, the wave will go out and we understand that. Or if we were mis-attuned with, if we were screamed at when we were in desperation, if we were ignored when we were in our grief and terror, this creates a belief that emotions, especially the body, emotions and the body are not to be trusted. That you will get swept away in your emotion and you will never return.

Essentially feelings are dangerous and being in your body, being present in your body is dangerous. Take some nice deep breaths. If this is intense for you, it was very intense for me when I first learned this too, so I understand. The third here is that the quality of security, attunement, and curiosity from our caregivers creates a belief that "my experience matters. I am worth being seen, heard, and understood. I make sense. I understand who I am." Or, "I don't matter. I am not worthy of love and understanding. My thoughts don't make sense. I don't even know who I am." I hope that this is sinking in for you and you're making the connection.

So attachment is the quality of connection between the infant and the caregiver. Secure attachment is created by consistent, predictable, warm, nurturing responses to an infant, a toddler, or any young child. Because of the power over parenting paradigm, and the power under parenting paradigm, many of us are now parents who do not have a secure attachment to ourselves. Therefore, we don't trust our feelings. We don't even feel them, maybe. We don't trust our body. So witnessing our children in their feelings and in their body, especially their aggression, it is viscerally painful. We don't understand what our children are thinking. "Why would you do that?" We're dumb founded. We have a block of empathy and curiosity. We're judgmental, and we're critical. We're not connected to ourselves. We don't have a coherent understanding of our experiences. We don't have the ability to connect our childhood experiences with the pattern of showing up now in our parenting. There's missing pieces, there's fragmentation. It's really hard to feel safe in your body. It's really hard to feel self connected to yourself, to trust yourself, to be confident, to be strong, to be brave, to be courageous, to be a leader, to be an empowered parent, when you are lacking security inside of yourself. That makes sense to me. It makes sense to me, why you've read every parenting book that there is, and you're still struggling every day. It takes time to create a secure attachment, if you were raised in a power over or power under parenting paradigm. Even if your parents loved you, which I'm sure they did, it's not about your parents and their love for you. It is about the reality of where we are as humans. We are just learning this. This is new for almost every family on this planet. It is not just you. This is not personal. This is a revolution in every home on this planet. We are just learning and it's difficult to soften that cycle of disconnection and insecurity and separation, and it's possible. Do you remember my intention? It's hope! That's why you're here. I'm not here to dump doom onto you and tell you that if you didn't have a secure attachment in your childhood, best of luck to you. Not at all, the best part about all of this science is that there's so much hope. And we're figuring out how to do it to a teeny tiny molecularly neurologically level. We're learning how. And it's so exciting. I'm so happy! Because that's what you deserve, and that you've always deserved.



You have always deserved to be cared for at this quality, this depth, this consistency, predictability, reliability, warmth, generosity, kindness, respect, and that's how you deserve to treat yourself right now. That's how your children deserve to be treated. And that's the quality of relationship that you and your child deserve to have. That is your birthright. We are here biologically hardwired to connect and have secure, beautiful, remarkable, invigorating, collaborative connections, family. Are you feeling the hope? Is it just me? I'll feel it for you.

So we have a workbook this week that showcases to you the four styles of attachment. There is secure attachment, which is nearly impossible to create a perfectly secure attachment, and that's not the goal. There are three styles of insecure attachment. There is insecure avoidant, insecure ambivalent, and insecure disorganized. You will read through that in the workbook. Please breathe as you're reading this, if it's stressful for you. I understand, that makes sense to me. And take a nice deep breath, take a break from the audio or from the workbook, if you need to. And then the best part is we get to learn how to create and earn a secure attachment, which is what we'll be doing together the next, however many weeks, it is. We will be looking at the four S's of an earned secure attachment, and we'll start by beginning, creating a coherent narrative. So Daniel Siegel and Tina Payne Bryson have learned that the first step of creating a secure attachment is making sense of your childhood story, making sense of your parenting past. And we'll be doing that slowly together throughout the rest of this process. We'll be looking at the four S's, safe, seen, soothed and secure, and there's going to be a lot of fun and a lot of science and information, which is what I love.

We'll end the audio today with a powerful message that no matter the success of these 10 pillars of an empowered parent, you're able to access and deliver on a daily basis, the greatest gift that you can give your children is to show up. And first, before you can show up for your children, you must show up for yourself. And the beautiful news is you have found the place that is going to support you to do that. Everything here was created for you to solidify your internal foundation, create a coherent narrative of your parenting past and your childhood story, cultivate a sense of safety in your body, your heart, and your mind, create an understanding of how to see and be seen, and to learn how to soothe all of the parts within yourself that are longing to be tended to with non-judgment and compassion. And finally, we'll celebrate earning a secure attachment and giving the same to your children. Thank you so much for being here with me today. I sincerely invite you to allow yourself to feel hopeful from this audio and this workbook, because there is infinite hope and this is an amazing time to be alive and an amazing time to be a parent. Thank you so much. I'll see you next time.

